

Ancient Egyptian temples

Built for the worship of gods, ancient Egyptian temples evolved from small shrines to large complexes. By the time of the New Kingdom (c.1550–1070 BCE), temples had become massive stone structures consisting of enclosed halls, open courts and entrance pylons. Certain parts could only be entered by priests, but the public visited other areas to pray, give offerings and seek guidance from the gods.

Notable examples include the Temple of Khons, built in 1198 BCE, with an avenue of sphinxes leading to an obelisk and hypostyle (columned) hall. Queen Hatshepsut's temple, designed by the architect Senenmut, was a geometric edifice dug into a rock face, built in 323 BCE. Its extended, double-colonnaded terraces are on three levels connected by ramps. The two Abu Simbel temples are also massive rock-cut structures, commissioned by Rameses II as monuments for himself (opposite) and his queen Nefertari. The entire complex was relocated in 1968 to avoid being submerged in Lake Nasser.

